

Martin Nilsson | CV

Independent Golf Agronomic Consultant | Zero-Pesticide & Links-Style Turf Management | Strategic & Operational Advisory

Professional Profile

Practitioner-led golf agronomic consultant with more than 20 years of hands-on experience from one of Europe's most respected and tightly regulated golf courses. Proven track record in guiding an elite course through the full transition from conventional turf management to resilient, high-quality, zero-pesticide systems without compromising playability.

Combines long-term operational leadership with independent advisory capability. Particularly valued for calm decision-making under pressure, objective advice rooted in real-world practice, and the ability to guide clubs step by step through complex agronomic transitions under climatic, operational and legislative constraints.

Selected Highlights

- Successfully transitioned a top European golf course from conventional to fully pesticide-free management while maintaining year-round playability and member confidence.
 - Established durable, low-input turf systems based on fine grasses (fescues & browntop bent), reducing disease pressure and operational volatility.
 - Recognised reference site for sustainable golf course management, hosting regular international educational visits and contributing to applied research and industry best practice.
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Core Competencies

- Integrated pest management, disease prevention and management
- Objective, independent agronomic advice (zero-pesticides environments)
- Links-style & coastal/low-input turf management
- Maintenance strategies for playability, uniformity & resilience
- Soil structure, sand selection, irrigation & drainage
- Climate-driven decision-making (wind, drought, seasonal stress)
- Environmental legislation & ecological compliance
- Agronomic reporting, seasonal evaluations & long-term optimisation
- Coaching, knowledge transfer & team sparring

Professional Experience

Royal Copenhagen Golf Club – Denmark

Head Greenkeeper | 2006 – 2025

Head Greenkeeper at Scandinavia's oldest and one of the most prestigious golf clubs, located in a historically protected public park and operating under one of Europe's strictest environmental regulatory frameworks.

Key Responsibilities & Achievements

- Led the complete transition from conventional turf management to a resilient, fully pesticide-free maintenance model.
- Continuous monitoring of turf health with calm, effective response to disease pressure and stress situations without chemical plant protection.
- Developed and executed long-term maintenance strategies ensuring quality of play, uniformity and resilience across greens, fairways and tees.
- Reintroduced fine grasses (red fescue and browntop bent) as dominant species through a disciplined, links-style, low-input management regime.
- Designed and implemented non-chemical disease suppression methods, including rolling-based Microdochium patch control (later documented through R&A/STERF-supported research).
- Extensive experience with fertilisation programmes, biostimulants, soil improvement and alternative weed control techniques.
- Primary liaison with public authorities and stakeholders regarding environmental protection, water preservation, Natura2000 and heritage legislation.
- Overall responsibility for maintenance budgets (€1–1.5m annually) and staff leadership (4–12 employees).

Construction, Renovation & Technical Works

- **Full Course Reconstruction (2008–2009):** Member of project group working with architect Tom Mackenzie (Mackenzie & Ebert) and contractor Frank Lowell. Renovation of all 18 holes, including tees, bunkers and green surrounds.
 - **Short Game Area Development (2022):** Architect Phillip Spogard (Spogard & Vandervaart) Achieved regulatory approval to relocate protected habitats, enabling construction within strict nature conservation constraints. A first in Denmark.
 - **Irrigation Infrastructure (2020):** Planning and establishment of a new borehole for sustainable water supply.
 - **Forward Tees Programme (2015):** Architect Tom Mackenzie (Mackenzie & Ebert) Planning and construction of forward tees on six holes.
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Links-Style & Zero-Pesticide Expertise

More than 20 years of links-style turf management in an exposed, wind-affected, low-input environment. Deep understanding of managing sand-based soils under drought stress, seasonal variability and tightening legislation. Proven ability to maintain technical and visual quality while reducing chemical dependency and intervention intensity.

Professional Network, Knowledge Exchange & Consultant Skills

- Co-founder and long-standing member of an experience group of leading Danish head greenkeepers focused on sustainable, pesticide-free management.
- Sparring partner to various head greenkeepers in Denmark and abroad.
- Broad insight into multiple golf courses, approaches and challenges through continuous professional sparring focused on agronomic evaluations, seasonal recommendations and long-term strategies.
- Host of 4–5 educational visits annually at Royal Copenhagen GC for European greenkeepers and industry professionals with the purpose of understanding pesticide-free turf management.

Industry Leadership & Representation

- Vice-President, **FEGGA** (Federation of European Golf Greenkeepers Associations) (2022-present)
 - **FEGGA** Representative, **European Golf Association (EGA) Strategic Working Group** (2023-present)
 - Chairman, **Danish Greenkeepers Association (DGA)** (2008–2017)
 - **DGA** Representative in negotiations with the Danish Environmental Protection Agency on implementation of the EU Sustainable Use Directive (2013-2017)
 - Advisory Board Member, **Scandinavian Turfgrass Research Foundation** (since 2008)
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Conferences & Publications

- Speaker at greenkeeping conferences and workshops across Scandinavia, the UK, France, Czech Republic and the Netherlands.
 - Contributor to industry publications, including features in *Greenkeeper International*.
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Education

Professional Greenkeeper Education, Denmark | 2001–2005

BSc in Business Administration and Economics, Copenhagen Business School | 1989 - 1992

References

Available upon request

Contact Details

Martin Nilsson

Lillevangsvej 32, 3520 Farum, DK-Denmark

Phone: +45 53750727

Mail: martinnilsson647@outlook.com